Demo: From Observed Treasury Yields to Hull–White Future Curves

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This reading copy shows the calculations' results and figures. The HTML demo contains the full code in folded blocks and interactive scenario controls.

1 Goal

This demo follows one complete fixed-income workflow:

1. start with a **dated U.S. Treasury par-yield snapshot**;
2. bootstrap today's discount factors and zero-coupon yield curve;
3. calibrate Hull–White so that it exactly respects that curve;
4. fit the model's mean reversion and volatility to a supplied synthetic option quote snapshot that demonstrates the calibration mechanics;
5. generate yield curves at a future date in different interest-rate states; and
6. use those future curves to price remaining bond cash flows.

The initial curve uses the U.S. Treasury's published **January 2, 2025** par-yield snapshot. Treasury par yields are bond-equivalent quoted rates; bootstrapped zero rates are continuously compounded. The option premiums used later are synthetic.

Source: U.S. Treasury, Daily Treasury Par Yield Curve Rates.

> **The central idea**
>
> Today's curve determines today's prices. Hull–White adds a disciplined way to describe *future* curves. Calibration makes those two statements consistent.

2 Setup

2.1 Read the workflow in two layers

Valuation today: dated Treasury par yields → constructed annual-pay par coupon bonds → bootstrapped discount factors → present value of fixed cash flows. These constructed instruments are a curve-building convention, not individual Treasury securities or their actual coupons.

Uncertainty tomorrow: supplied synthetic option premiums → fitted mean reversion a and volatility σ → curve-consistent drift $\theta(t)$ → future short-rate state r_t → future discount curve → remaining bond value. The premiums illustrate calibration; they are not observed option quotes. The second layer must preserve the first. A complicated model is not allowed to change today's price of fixed cash flows once the discount curve is fixed.

Open **Show calculation** to inspect each step. The final explorer lets you change the input curve, model parameters, and future short-rate state.

3 Record the observed Treasury curve

The published Treasury series contains par yields at standard maturity nodes. We retain the 1-, 2-, 3-, 5-, 7-, and 10-year observations and linearly interpolate missing integer maturities. The interpolation is an **estimated curve-construction choice**, not an additional market quote. For transparent annual bootstrapping we treat each interpolated par yield as the coupon on an annual-pay par bond. A production Treasury curve would instead use security-level prices, semiannual coupons, actual day counts, accrued interest, and bills at the short end.

Observation date	Maturity (years)	Observed Treasury par yield (%)	Annual par coupon rate (%)	Const
2025-01-02	1	4.17	4.17	100
2025-01-02	2	4.25	4.25	100
2025-01-02	3	4.29	4.29	100
2025-01-02	4		4.335	100
2025-01-02	5	4.38	4.38	100
2025-01-02	6		4.425	100
2025-01-02	7	4.47	4.47	100
2025-01-02	8		4.503333	100
2025-01-02	9		4.536667	100
2025-01-02	10	4.57	4.57	100

Observed nodes are facts from the dated snapshot. Interpolated nodes and the annual-pay par-bond representation are assumptions. That separation matters: a curve can fit its inputs perfectly while still depending on construction choices.

4 Bootstrap today's discount curve

For the one-year bond, the only cash flow is coupon plus principal, so its price immediately gives $P(0,1)$. For each later bond, discount factors for earlier coupons are already known. The final discount factor is the only unknown:

$$P(0,n) = \frac{100 - \sum_{i=1}^{n-1} C_n P(0,i)}{100 + C_n}, \qquad C_n = 100 c_n.$$

Maturity (years)	Discount factor P(0,T)	Continuous zero rate (%)
1	0.959969	4.085399
2	0.920097	4.163799
3	0.881528	4.203298
4	0.84371	4.248659
5	0.806752	4.294781
6	0.770665	4.3417
7	0.735457	4.389466
8	0.701877	4.424966
9	0.669306	4.461266
10	0.637732	4.498374

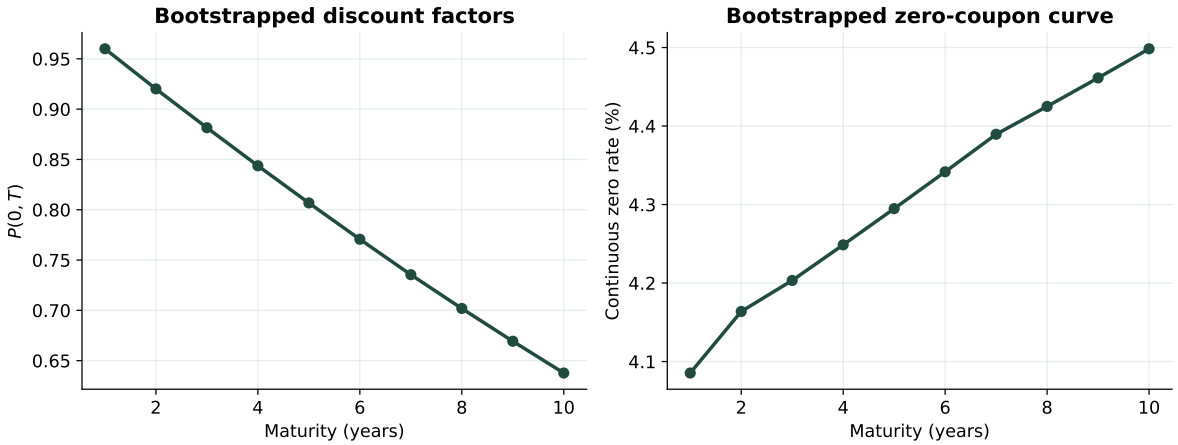


Figure 1: Today's curve recovered from constructed par coupon bonds

4.1 Check the bootstrap by repricing every input bond

A useful calibration habit is to return to the original observable quantities.

Maturity (years)	Annual par coupon rate (%)	Constructed price per 100	Input status	Repri
1	4.17	100	Observed Treasury node	100
2	4.25	100	Observed Treasury node	100
3	4.29	100	Observed Treasury node	100
4	4.335	100	Interpolated node	100
5	4.38	100	Observed Treasury node	100
6	4.425	100	Interpolated node	100
7	4.47	100	Observed Treasury node	100

Maturity (years)	Annual par coupon rate (%)	Constructed price per 100	Input status	Repri
8	4.503333	100	Interpolated node	100
9	4.536667	100	Interpolated node	100
10	4.57	100	Observed Treasury node	100

```
Largest absolute repricing error: 0.0000000000 per 100 face
```

5 Fit the Hull–White dynamics to option prices

The lecture's calibration logic separates two jobs:

- the piecewise-constant function $\theta(t)$ fits every bootstrapped discount target; and
- a and σ control future mean reversion and volatility.

In practice, a and σ are fitted to liquid caps, floors, or swaptions. To keep the code transparent, our artificial option market consists of European calls on zero-coupon bonds. These option premiums could be observed in a suitable market dataset; the premiums below are synthetic. Hull–White has a closed-form pricing formula for them.

5.1 Hull–White building blocks

For the one-factor model

$$dr_t = [\theta(t) - ar_t]dt + \sigma dW_t^{\mathbb{Q}},$$

t is the valuation time and $T > t$ is a payment maturity, both measured in years. r_t is the instantaneous short rate; a is mean reversion (per year), σ is short-rate volatility (per square root of a year), and $\theta(t)$ is the time-dependent drift intercept. $W_t^{\mathbb{Q}}$ is Brownian motion under the risk-neutral pricing measure. Lowercase a is a scalar parameter; uppercase $A(t,T)$ below is a bond-pricing coefficient, not that parameter.

The zero-coupon bond price is

$$P(t,T) = A(t,T)e^{-B(t,T)r_t}, \qquad B(t,T) = \frac{1 - e^{-a(T-t)}}{a}.$$

For the piecewise-constant drift used here,

$$A(t,T) = \exp\left[-\int_t^T \theta(u)B(u,T)\,du + \frac{\sigma^2}{2}\int_t^T B(u,T)^2\,du\right].$$

Capital $A(t,T)$ incorporates the fitted drift and volatility; lowercase a controls mean reversion. The calculation evaluates the interval integrals directly. Given r_t and the fitted model, this gives the price of one unit paid at T.

Write the model option premium compactly as

$$C^{\text{model}}(S,T,K;a,\sigma,\theta(a,\sigma),r_0).$$

S is the option expiry, $T > S$ is the underlying zero-coupon bond's maturity, and K is the strike paid at expiry. The underlying principal and option premium are quoted per 100 of face value. For each candidate (a,σ), the vector $\theta(a,\sigma)$ is refitted to the bootstrap discount targets. The starting state is fixed at $r_0 = -\log P^{\text{boot}}(0,T_1)/T_1$, a convention rather than a separate overnight-rate observation.

5.2 Create a synthetic option quote snapshot

We create at-the-money-forward calls with expiries from six months to five years. The hidden values $a = 0.18$ per year and $\sigma = 1.20\%$ per square root of a year are used only to generate the synthetic premiums. A small alternating bid/ask-like perturbation prevents a mechanically perfect parameter recovery.

Option expiry (years)	Bond maturity (years)	Strike per 100	Synthetic option premium per 100
0.5	5.5	80.51466	0.84472
1	6	80.28013	1.11236
1.5	6.5	80.06017	1.28144
2	7	79.93258	1.3817
3	8	79.62052	1.50171
4	9	79.32891	1.53621
5	10	79.04931	1.53548

5.3 Calibrate a and σ with a simple grid search

For the supplied synthetic premiums C_j^{supplied}, choose the parameters that minimize the root-mean-square pricing error:

$$(\hat{a}, \hat{\sigma}) = \underset{a,\sigma}{\operatorname{argmin}} \sqrt{\frac{1}{M} \sum_{j=1}^{M} \left[C^{\text{model}}(S_j, T_j, K_j; a, \sigma, \theta(a, \sigma), r_0) - C_j^{\text{supplied}} \right]^2}.$$

M is the number of option quotes; S_j, T_j, and K_j identify each contract. The grid below tries candidate values of lowercase a and σ. Each candidate refits the drift constants to the same bootstrap targets before pricing the options, including discounts at fractional maturities. Capital $A(t, T)$ remains a bond-pricing coefficient, not a parameter being estimated.

```
Calibrated mean reversion a: 0.1790 per year
Calibrated volatility sigma: 1.1919% per sqrt(year)
Option-price RMSE: 0.005443 per 100 face
```

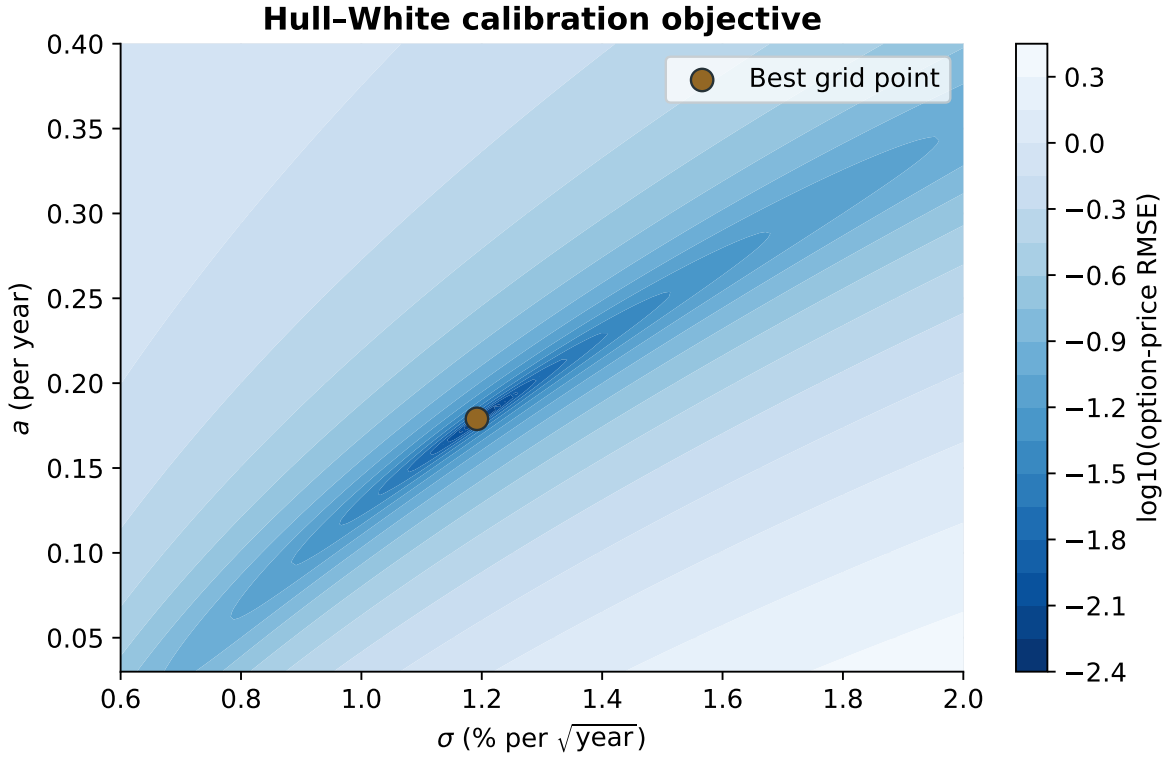


Figure 2: Option-pricing error across candidate Hull–White parameters

Option expiry (years)	Bond maturity (years)	Strike per 100	Synthetic option premium per 100	Model p
0.5	5.5	80.514656	0.844722	0.838561
1	6	80.280132	1.11236	1.110013

Option expiry (years)	Bond maturity (years)	Strike per 100	Synthetic option premium per 100	Model p
1.5	6.5	80.060172	1.281444	1.273887
2	7	79.932583	1.381698	1.380736
3	8	79.620518	1.501708	1.495199
4	9	79.328909	1.536209	1.533078
5	10	79.049312	1.535476	1.528147

6 Fit the time-dependent drift to today's curve

Let $0 = T_0 < T_1 < \cdots < T_N$ be the actual bootstrap dates. Use one unknown constant per interval:

$$\theta(t) = \theta_i \quad \text{for } T_{i-1} \le t < T_i, \qquad i = 1, \dots, N.$$

The boundaries and the fitted values together define the full drift function. The final value continues after T_N. Here N is the number of bootstrap targets, computed from the data; it is not a hard-coded choice.

For each fixed pair (a, σ) and the chosen r_0, solve

$$P^{\text{model}}(0, T_i; a, \sigma, \theta_1, \dots, \theta_N) = P^{\text{boot}}(0, T_i), \qquad i = 1, \dots, N.$$

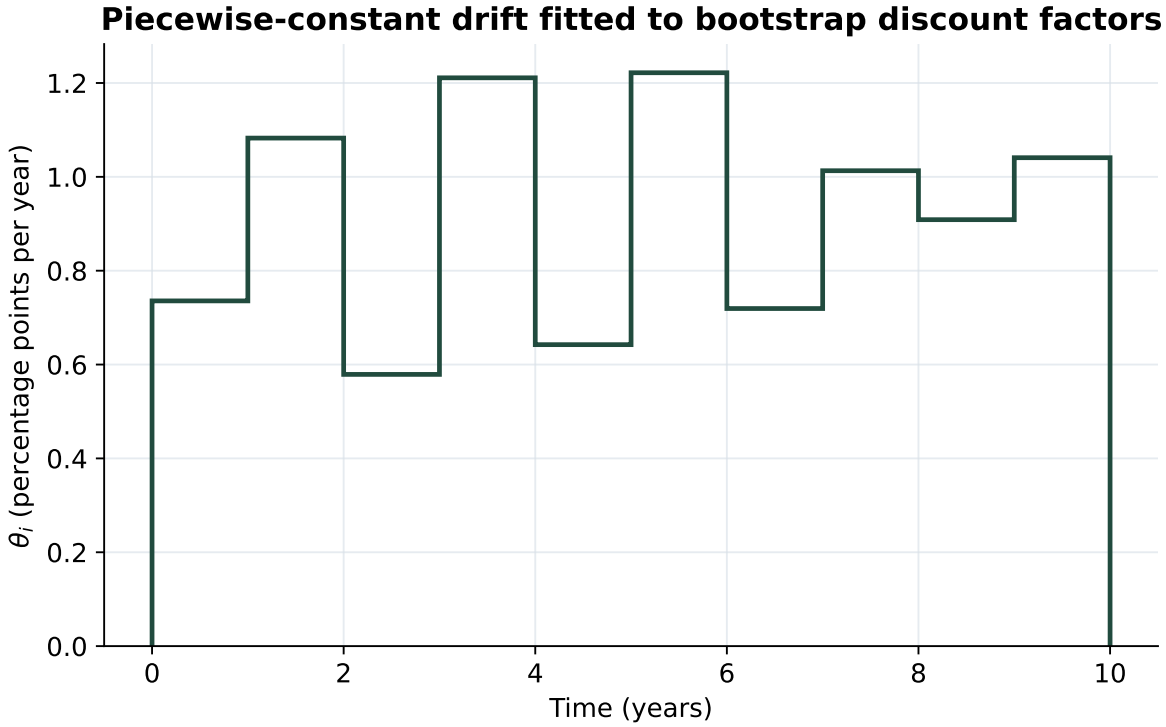
How the fit works: choose θ_1 to match the first target. Keep it fixed, choose θ_2 to match the second, and continue. Later intervals cannot affect an earlier payment, so this is a sequential solve. The Gaussian model makes each equation linear in the unknown drift constants when written in log-discount form. No derivatives of an interpolated curve are required.

The fitted $\theta(t)$ is a drift intercept: the rate's conditional drift is $\theta(t) - ar_t$, not $\theta(t)$ alone. Changing a or σ changes the constants needed to match the same initial targets, which is why the option-calibration loop refits them for each candidate pair.

Interval start (years)	Interval end (years)	Drift intercept theta (decimal rate/year)
0	1	0.007357
1	2	0.010826
2	3	0.00579
3	4	0.01211
4	5	0.006424
5	6	0.012218
6	7	0.007194

Interval start (years)	Interval end (years)	Drift intercept theta (decimal rate/year)
7	8	0.01013
8	9	0.009087
9	10	0.010408

```
Fitted intervals: 10; final value extends past year 10.
```



6.1 Verify that Hull–White reproduces today's discount curve

Use the fitted model to calculate

$$P^{\text{model}}(0, T_i) = A(0, T_i)e^{-B(0,T_i)r_0}$$

and compare it with $P^{\text{boot}}(0, T_i)$ at each bootstrap maturity. These are **prices of one unit paid at maturity**, not the par coupon-bond price of 100. The differences below should be zero apart from numerical rounding. Between these nodes, the same fitted model supplies the discount curve.

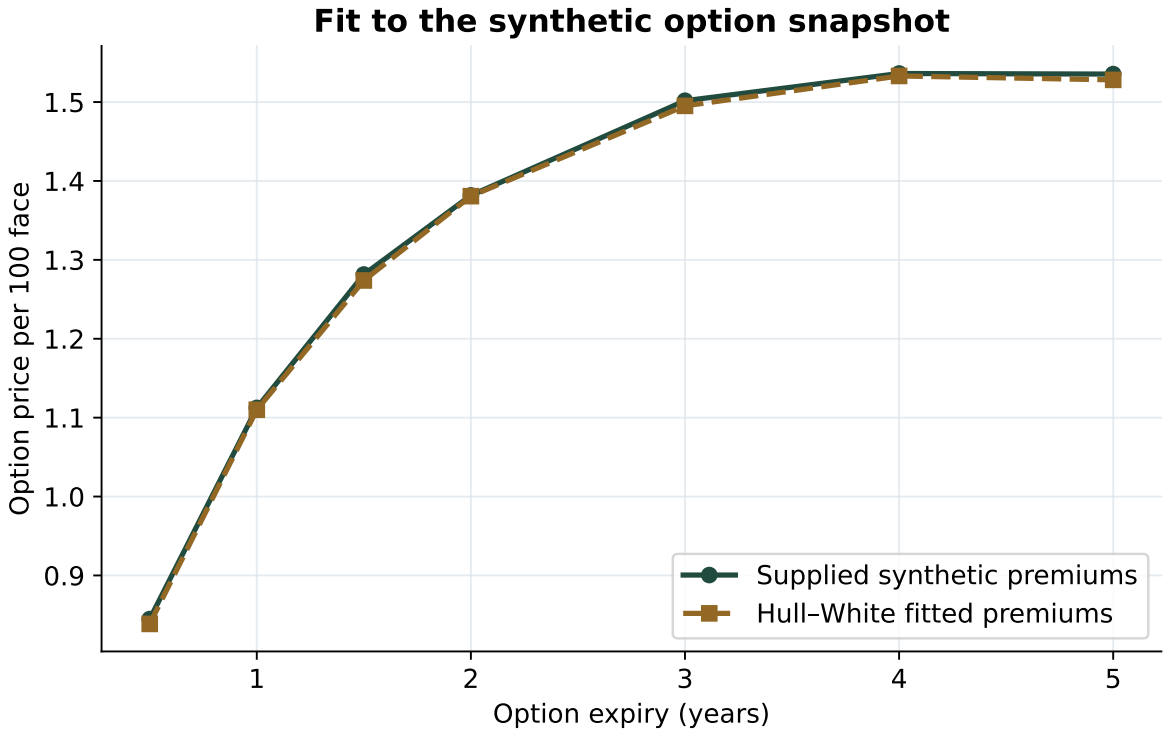


Figure 3: Observed artificial option premiums and calibrated Hull–White prices

Maturity (years)	Initial P(0,T)	Hull–White P(0,T)	Difference
1	0.959969	0.959969	0
2	0.920097	0.920097	0
3	0.881528	0.881528	0
4	0.84371	0.84371	0
5	0.806752	0.806752	0
6	0.770665	0.770665	0
7	0.735457	0.735457	0
8	0.701877	0.701877	0
9	0.669306	0.669306	0
10	0.637732	0.637732	0

7 Generate future yield curves

Move to year 2. In a one-factor Hull–White model, the short rate r_2 is the single state variable. Hold the initial curve, a, and σ fixed. For a simulated or selected r_2, calculate $B(2,T)$ and $A(2,T)$ at each future payment date, then obtain $P(2,T) = A(2,T)e^{-B(2,T)r_2}$. Convert each conditional bond price to its continuously compounded zero yield:

$$y(2,T) = -\frac{\log P(2,T)}{T-2}.$$

We show three possible states around the model's central short-rate level. They are scenarios, not point forecasts.

Rate state	Short rate (%)	Maturity (years)	Continuous zero rate (%)
Low-rate state	2.91	2.25	2.917
Low-rate state	2.91	2.3481	2.92
Low-rate state	2.91	2.4462	2.923
Central state	4.41	2.25	4.384
Central state	4.41	2.3481	4.374
Central state	4.41	2.4462	4.364
High-rate state	5.91	2.25	5.851
High-rate state	5.91	2.3481	5.829
High-rate state	5.91	2.4462	5.806

Notice that one factor moves the whole curve in a structured way. Mean reversion causes the effect of today's short-rate state to weaken at longer maturities because the zero-yield sensitivity is $B(t,T)/(T-t)$: $B(t,T)$ approaches $1/a$ while remaining maturity grows.

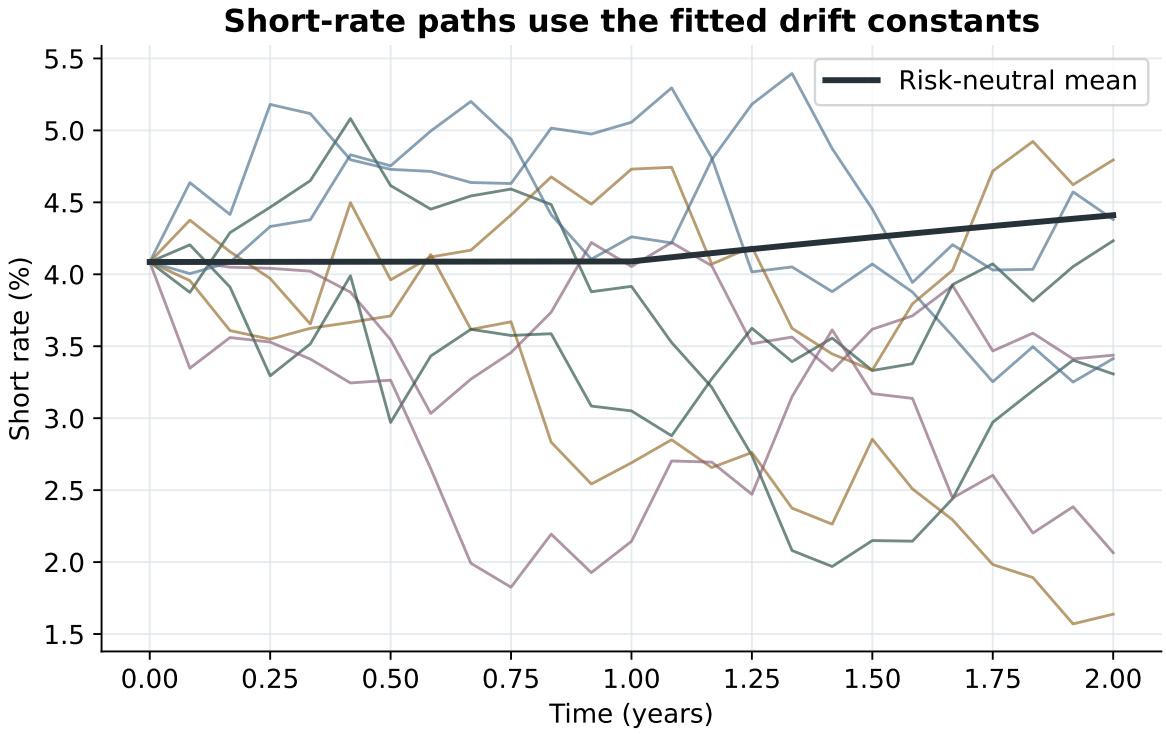


Figure 4: Exact Gaussian sample paths under the fitted piecewise-constant drift

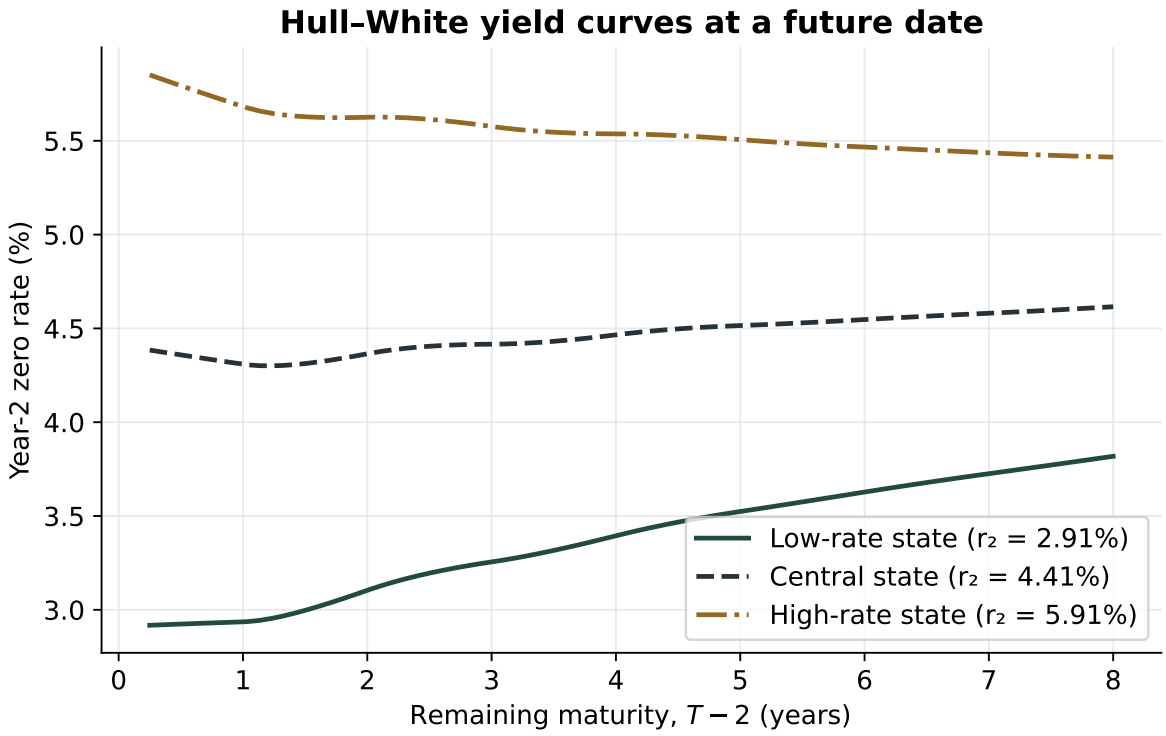


Figure 5: At year 2, one short-rate state determines a complete remaining yield curve

8 Use a future curve to price a bond

Consider the original ten-year 4.10% coupon bond at year 2, immediately after its year-2 coupon has been paid. Eight coupons and the principal remain. Its value in each state is simply the discounted value of those remaining cash flows using $P(2,T)$.

Rate state	Short rate (%)	Year-2 bond value per 100
Low-rate state	2.9105	101.7261
Central state	4.4105	96.0321
High-rate state	5.9105	90.6729

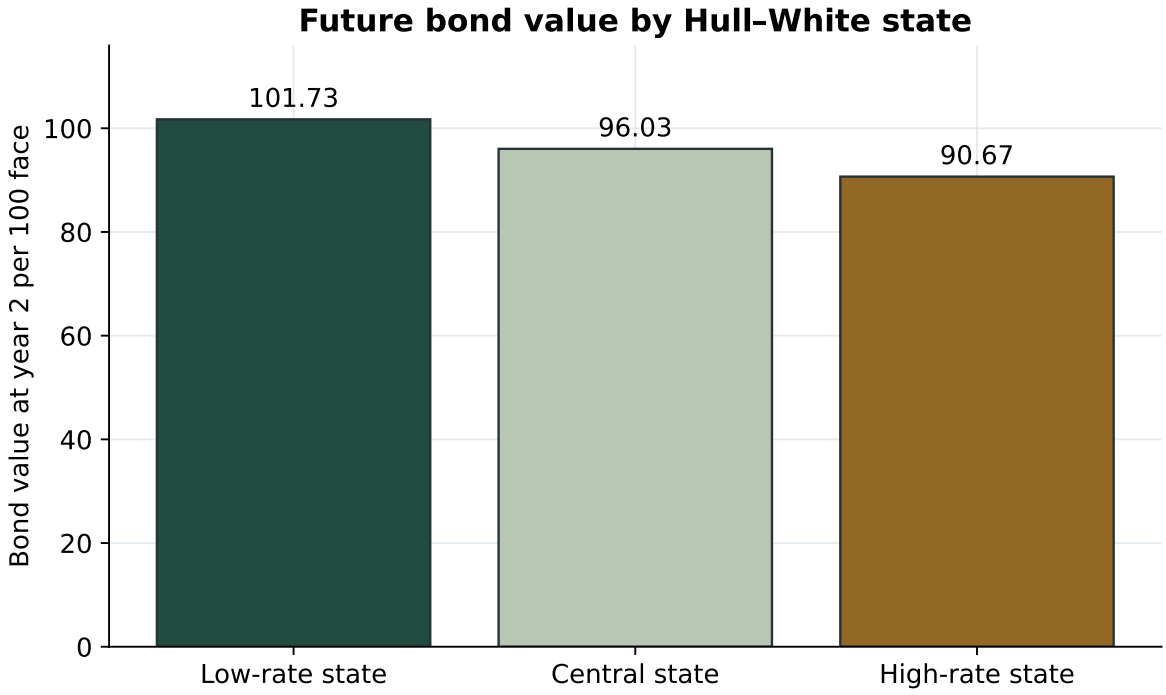


Figure 6: The same promised cash flows have different values in different year-2 rate states

This future valuation is where a short-rate model becomes useful. Today we do not observe $P(2,T)$; Hull–White generates it consistently for each possible r_2.

9 Plain-bond consistency at time 0

Finally, verify the lecture's important claim: once Hull–White is calibrated to the observed curve, it does **not** create a different time-0 price for a vanilla bond. Both methods discount

the same fixed cash flows with the same $P(0,T)$.

```
Direct observed-curve price: 96.2742663687
Calibrated Hull-White price:  96.2742663687
Difference:                    0.000000000000
```

The equality follows from the node fit: every payment date in this annual-pay bond is a bootstrap date, where the model matches the target discount factor. For a vanilla bond, the model adds no new pricing information. Its value is the ability to generate future curves and to value cash flows that depend on those future states.

10 Checks and interpretation

The workflow has three separate fits, each with a different purpose:

Calibration object	Observable input	What is fitted	Why it matters
Today's discount curve	Coupon-bond prices	$P(0,T)$	Prices fixed cash flows today
Initial Hull–White term structure	Bootstrapped $P(0,T_i)$	Interval constants θ_i	Matches every bootstrap target within one Gaussian model
Future dynamics	Interest-rate option premiums	a, σ	Controls mean reversion and uncertainty

```
Largest initial-node fit error: 1.110e-16
Candidate-parameter node fit error: 1.110e-16
Discounted conditional-price consistency error: 0.000e+00
```

Check	passed
Each candidate refits the bootstrap targets	True
Conditional and initial pricing agree at fractional dates	True
Immediate payment has unit discount factor	True
Bootstrap reprices input bonds	True
Discount factors are positive	True
Discount factors decrease with maturity	True
Hull–White matches all bootstrap targets	True

Check	passed
Two vanilla-bond pricing methods agree	True

11 Takeaways

> **Separate calibration from a scenario**
>
> First compare observed and interpolated nodes. Then inspect the option-fit error: an exact fit to today's curve does not guarantee an exact fit to every option. Finally change only the future short-rate state. Today's curve stays unchanged, but the future bond value changes. Explain why the year-2 value excludes coupons already paid and is not a two-year holding-period total return.

Market handoff: the embedded Treasury observations are a reproducible dated snapshot, not today's curve. Replace the entire dated node table together, retain the observed/interpolated labels, and rerun every check. Keep the supplied synthetic option prices if a permitted option dataset is unavailable; do not label recovered parameters as empirically calibrated market dynamics.

- Market bond prices can be converted into discount factors by bootstrapping.
- Hull–White does not fit a whole curve using only two constants. The function θ_i values fit today's bootstrap targets; a and σ describe future dynamics.
- Option prices provide information about those dynamics that vanilla bond prices do not.
- At a future date, each one-factor Hull–White short-rate state produces a complete yield curve and a value for the remaining cash flows.
- A vanilla bond has the same time-0 value under calibrated Hull–White and direct curve discounting. The model earns its keep when future rates affect valuation or cash flows.

> **Simplifications**
>
> Real desks use multiple instrument types, day-count conventions, accrued interest, bid/ask spreads, smooth curve interpolation, and robust numerical optimizers. The demo deliberately removes those layers so the economic logic stays visible.

12 Interactive explorer

Change the **Treasury par-yield input curve**, mean reversion a, or volatility σ. Every change rebuilds the annual par instruments, bootstraps discount targets, refits all θ_i, and updates the

model-implied future short-rate distribution. The baseline is the dated input snapshot and the option-calibrated parameters above. Manual parameter changes here are scenarios, not a new option calibration.

The initial state is always reset consistently to $r_0 = -\log P^{\text{boot}}(0, T_1)/T_1$. A curve-only change holds a and σ fixed: the future mean changes, but the Gaussian short-rate variance does not. Changing a, σ, or the horizon changes

$$\text{Var}^{\mathbb{Q}}(r_h \mid r_0) = \frac{\sigma^2}{2a}(1 - e^{-2ah}).$$

The future yield-curve panel is conditional on the selected short-rate state at the chosen horizon. At zero standard deviations this is the curve at the risk-neutral mean state, not an expected future yield curve. Move the state control to compare higher or lower rate states.

The band contains the central 95% of the model's risk-neutral short-rate distribution. It is not a confidence interval for a physical forecast. The final drift constant extends after the last bootstrap date, including when the displayed five-year bond matures beyond that date.

The HTML explorer recomputes the bootstrap, drift constants, future short-rate distribution, and a conditional bond price for each curve or parameter change. The preceding static tables and figures use the baseline inputs and fitted parameters.